things back on the morning of day four, it was going to be difficult to save the match. Zaheer and Ishant bowled very well in the English second innings but it was Zaheer's spell of three wickets in five overs, including the centurion Collingwood, that brought us back into the game. For the first time we sensed we had the opposition on the back foot and it was now up to the batsmen to chase down the target of 387. It would not be easy – in fact it would be the highest ever run chase on Indian soil – but under Gary we had started to believe that anything was possible.

Sehwag set up the match wonderfully by scoring a brilliant counter-attacking 83 on the fourth evening. It was an innings of outstanding ability. I went in to bat on the morning of the final day and for the first hour or so just tried to soak up the pressure. Once we had weathered the early storm we started to look for runs. Every positive stroke put the pressure back on England and slowly but steadily the balance started to tilt in our favour.

Laxman and I had a good partnership and once Laxman fell, Yuvraj joined me in the middle. I was determined to bat till the end of the match. Indians love cricket and if, for just a minute or two, a victory in Chennai could lift their mood after everything that had happened, I would feel humbled.

Yuvraj batted well under pressure, making 85. There was a time in his innings when he attempted to play the reverse sweep to Monty Panesar and I walked up to him to tell him that all he needed to do was remain not out and finish the game. I reminded him of the Pakistan game at Chennai in 1999 and said I had been in a similar position before and remembered well how painful it was to lose from a winning position. Yuvraj reined himself in and we finally reached our target in the last hour of the fifth day. I had scored an unbeaten hundred for the team, but it was the extra significance of the game that made it particularly gratifying. In a first in Indian cricket, even the groundswomen, who hardly ever came to the foreground, celebrated the victory with great vigour. As we were walking back to the changing rooms, I was asked who I planned to dedicate the hundred to. I had not thought about it and was still very much in the moment, but on behalf of the team I dedicated the victory to the victims of the terrorist attack.

India in New Zealand, one-day series, March 2009